

JOHN ATHAYDE

PRODUCT DESIGN PLAYER-COACH

3775 Stony Point Road, Charlottesville, Virginia 22911

202.285.3544 john@athayde.com

www.linkedin.com/in/johnathayde

www.github.com/jathayde



SUMMARY

Designing and shipping for the web since 1997. A product design player-coach who still writes the code. I work the seam between design and engineering as a senior voice for product teams: leading discovery, shaping systems, prototyping the direction, and (when it's the fastest way) shipping the front-end or full app to prove it. Twenty-plus years of brand-systems-applied-to-product (print, marcom, web, and app UI treated as one coherent surface), including current rebrand-through-product engagements like ATI (in progress) and an early packaged design system, Wilde, shipped as a Ruby gem and Bower package that unified 30 internal tools and Salesforce flows at LivingSocial. Currently running three Rails products as the sole PM, designer, and developer, using them as a working lab for design tokens, Lookbook, and AI-assisted design system workflows.

WHAT I DO

Brand-to-product parity: Running brand systems across every surface a company touches (print, marcom, digital, sales, trade show, app UI) and keeping them coherent as the org changes.

Design systems strategy and architecture: Token systems, component libraries, the design-to-engineering distribution layer, and the documentation that keeps them honest.

Design and engineering bridge work: Translating product strategy into structured technical plans, and prototyping in production code when it's the fastest path to alignment. Comfortable across Rails, React, Angular, .NET MVC, and Elixir front-ends.

Discovery and applied research: Service safaris, shadowing, AT-ONE, persona work, and the kind of deep listening that uncovers what the org actually needs before anyone draws a screen.

AI-assisted workflows: Figma to code pipelines (Tokens Studio, GitLab CI), MCP tooling, local inference, the Anthropic API, and Lookbook/Storybook as the design-system surface for AI tools to read and write against.

EXPERIENCE

Owner

Meticulous, LLC

Sep 1997 - Present

(Operated 2007 to 2008 as Hyphenated People with Amy Hoy, serving clients including Bear Stearns, Wine Library, Peracon, and Grab Networks.)

Solo-principal design and Rails practice serving enterprise, SaaS, and Rails-native clients. Recent and active engagements:

ATI (a Driven Brands company), full rebrand and product arc (ongoing) Multi-year contractor engagement covering the same pattern I ran at PowerFleet: full rebrand, brand guidelines applied across marketing, print, digital, and sales silos, reskinned the existing application and shipped the implementation in .NET MVC, and currently designing new product functionality with the internal team for the next version. The whole brand-systems-applied-to-product surface, end to end, with hands in both the design files and the production codebase.

Cybermaniacs, strategic design advisor (ongoing since August 2022) Long-running advisory engagement working alongside CEO Kate on both design and broader company direction: brand evolution and design review on the current website rollout, helping manage execution work with another design contractor, auditing the software platform after an engineer departure and proposing paths forward (including a possible Rails rebuild I'd lead), and sitting in on engineering hiring.

Xirgo / Elastic M2M, V3 Auto UX (6-month engagement, 2024 to 2025) Led UI refresh and design strategy for a multi-brand, multi-language, multi-device Angular-based IoT platform spanning web and mobile. Architected the design token system in Tokens Studio and built a Figma to GitLab CI pipeline to keep design and engineering in parity across white-label brand partners.

Procore, UX practice-building engagement (2015 to 2016) Invited in by Sam Crigman (then Head of Engineering, now CTO) after my RailsConf talk on dev-designer collaboration. Trained the org on UX discovery, helped hire the first two UX designers, designed the Change Management and Submittals modules (80+ screens and states), and established UX as a primary practice area before handing off. The team scaled to 15 within 12 months on the foundation we set. Procore went on to become the first AEC unicorn and IPO'd in 2021.

Rails Foundation (ongoing) UX, design, and front-end work on the Rails guides (both learner and API guides) and marketing site content build-outs (case studies, foundation members, and similar).

AI tooling and MCP exploration Built a series of autonomous agents (Scout, Bugle, and others) on top of the OpAgent framework, running on local inference and the Anthropic API, with integrations to HubSpot, Apollo, and Telegram. Currently experimenting with Figma Console MCP. Active in the MCP and Claude Code ecosystem for design ops, agency ops, and design-system context.

Earlier client work includes Lifetime Networks, Guggenheim Securities, RTKL Associates, The Academy for Educational Development, Ruby Central (print work), and others across UX/UI, brand, marcom, video, and Rails development.

Active Product Work: Sole PM, designer, and developer on three Rails products operated through Meticulous and Knightsbridge (the OSINT-focused research sister company):

PatchVault (Meticulous product). Development started 2013; in production with users since 2016. Patch design and trade documentation tooling for the Scouting community.

Rostergeek (Meticulous product). In rapid development; targeting public release Q3 2026.

Talos (Knightsbridge product). Internal use plus active client engagements; SaaS release in progress.

VP of Design

PowerFleet, Inc (formerly I.D. Systems, Inc.)

Feb 2019 - Aug 2022

Sole design leader through a transformative acquisition that doubled revenue and quadrupled global headcount.

- Rebranded the company end-to-end in Oct 2019 (web, print, video, trade show, brand guidelines) and relaunched on NASDAQ.
- - Reskinned the existing React platform, writing the CSS by hand against the engineering team's component structure, and authored brand-to-product guidelines for international subsidiaries to update their software modules in step with the new system.
- - Led reimagination of the next-generation platform: research, IA, user flows, wireframes, visual design, testing, and design system implementation.
- - Built a clickable prototype for an Intermodal Concept and a 6-minute concept video that sold the executive team on a global Connect platform refresh, which led to the PowerFleet Unity project in H1 '22.
- - Sourced and managed external contractors to deliver against enterprise scope without growing headcount.

VP Design

CargoSense, Inc.

Dec 2013 - Feb 2019

Sole design leader for a B2B IoT and logistics platform.

- - Partnered with CTO and CEO on product flows for web and mobile.
- - Built and maintained a design system with engineering for the Rails, React, and Elixir platform.
- - Established and maintained brand guidelines across multiple product offerings.

Lead: Internal Tools UI/UX

LivingSocial

Feb 2011 - Dec 2013

Led design and front-end development for the Internal Tools engineering division. Led a UX/front-end team of four as a player-coach.

- Led the Customer Support redesign that took agent SLA from 20% to 90% and dropped call abandonment from 20% to 4%, using service safari, AT-ONE framework, and extensive shadowing of CSRs across phone and email support.
- - The design language extracted from that redesign became *Wilde*, a packaged design system shipped as a Ruby gem and Bower package that powered the UI of 30 internal tools and skinned Salesforce flows, maintained by a small team. Pre-term-of-art design systems work at meaningful cross-stack scale..

UI/UX/Design Lead

InfoEther

Oct 2008 - Mar 2011 (Acquired by LivingSocial, March 2011.)

Sole UX/design and primary front-end developer for a Rails consultancy. Gathered requirements, designed, implemented, and shipped Rails interfaces. Designed print and web marketing materials and contributed to internal product strategy.

Earlier Roles

- *Creative Director / Senior Web Developer, InPhonic, Inc.* (2004 to 2007): built and ran the creative/microsites team from 4 to 15, managed 100+ jobs/month through pipeline.
- *Manager, Liquid Media Division, RTKL Associates* (2000 to 2001): DC office multimedia and 3D rendering coordination. Key projects: US Capitol Visitors Center, Pentagon Phoenix Project, US Capitol Security Perimeter

EDUCATION

Catholic University of America

Masters in Architecture, January 2001

Bachelor of Science in Architecture, June 2000

Permaculture Research Institute

Permaculture Design Certificate 2014

PUBLICATIONS & SPEAKING

The Rails View. 2013. Co-authored with Bruce Williams. Published by Pragmatic Programmers.

Recent talks: Blue Ridge Ruby 2026 (permaculture principles applied to UX), RailsConf 2025 ("UX & Design for Rails Devs"), Frontrunners 2022 ("Design Systems from Zero to One," George Mason University).

DeveloperUX, training curriculum for engineering teams on UX fundamentals, drawn from training the engineering orgs at Procore, LivingSocial, and others.